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Effects of Isolation and the Impact on Future Change

Change is an integral part of daily life and will directly impact the future. The one aspect of reform that is the same for every occurrence is the underlying choice to not dwell in isolation. Solitude creates a chasm between what is needing to happen and the ability to be actively involved in making a difference in the world. The prison of seclusion traps oneself in a critical position of helplessness. Change is not able to happen or be promoted when isolation has taken root in a person's life. Only by active involvement and outward courage will the bonds of solitude be broken. These bonds are not broken easily, but when they are, great rewards will be reaped. Future generations will be affected by the choices that are made today. This should serve as a noteworthy inspiration to break away from living life alone to joining the surrounding community in promoting needed changes.

In his essay "Making Our Lives Count," author Paul Rogat Loeb argues that personal involvement is necessary to elicit change. Humanity has the power to take ownership of the decisions that need to be made. He also articulates that human inclination is to remain silent and therefore drift into isolation. Loeb further outlines the consequences of isolation which include helplessness and the "erosion of our spirit" (565). As Loeb describes the ramifications of allowing solitude to take root, he compares it with the personal gain that is possible through dedicated active work. When challenging work is evident, and an example is set through direct involvement, change will occur. What the citizens of today do, whether it is to accept isolation or

get involved to promote change, will affect the world that is passed on to future generations.

Although Loeb identifies and offers ample evidence of the consequences of isolation and how it relates to change, he does not emphasize the courage it requires to transition from solitude into living a life of active involvement.

Courage is the bridge that connects isolation to the pursuit of active involvement with the purpose of promoting change. Without courage, the ability to break out of isolation will not be possible. Part of being brave is the willingness to look at how solitude has defined oneself and being willing to confront the false self-perceptions that have developed. Loeb briefly describes this when he writes, “We may need to question familiar habits, overcome self-doubt, and begin to separate who we really are from the roles we’ve been taught” (561). Only once courage has been summoned and used to defeat false views of oneself can isolation be broken. Life’s ambition has then been transformed into being an active vessel to encourage a better tomorrow. Change is challenging because without a resolution, seclusion will prevail, and active involvement will not occur. Portraying courage is not easy. It is the willingness to stand out for something that is believed in, even though it may not be well received. Being courageous is making the decision to make a life change so that there can be improvement in oneself. Courage is being willing to risk everything in the hope that by being actively involved in revolutionary change, others will join the cause.

Active involvement in common goals brings healing to the heart, but silence can kill the inner spirit of a person. Loeb describes the outcome of silence as, “Silence is more costly than speaking out, because it requires the ultimate sacrifice – the erosion of our spirit” (565).

Convictions are meant to be shared, not locked away and silenced. When beliefs are imprisoned and not allowed to break free, self-doubt and internal deprecation takes root, stealing the joy out

of life. Loeb further argues that “it takes energy to mute our voices...[but] social involvement reverses this process...reintegrating mind, heart, body and soul, so that we can speak in one voice”(565). To choke one’s voice is to dampen the inner spirit, which is difficult to overcome. A gathering of people encourages verbal dialogue and shared opinions. Solitude encourages negative self-reflection, insecurities, and the false hope that someone else will take care of the important aspects of life.

Dependency on others is born from isolation and the assumption that personal desires will be met without direct commitment or input. Loeb describes that people who are left to make decisions are often viewed as “social activists whose lifestyles seem impossibly selfless or foreign” (567). The people who speak out for change in the world are not necessarily selfless but rather determined and invested in seeing necessary issues resolved. It does not take a president, member of congress, or others with high social stature to vocally advocate for needed results. When the decision is to wait for citizens of certain occupations to take a stand, the power is given to them to define what the ending result will be as well. Loeb goes on to say, “It’s easier still to sit on the sidelines and simply hope our leaders will take care of things” (567). How often has humanity left debates up to someone in power and the result is not to the liking of certain individuals? History is filled with instances of disagreements and slander towards the figures of authority that promoted undesired changes. The only avenue available to encourage a desired result is to be actively involved in verbalizing and promoting the issue from the beginning. The willingness to promote an impactful modification will serve as encouragement to others to join the cause and nurture change as well.

Humanity was not created to live in solitude, but to reside as part of a community. Without being surrounded by society, Loeb suggests that the risk of growing “numb, detached,

[and] dead to the world around us” (565) will become a stark reality. Personal growth is only possible through interactions with other human beings and through challenging experiences (561). Loeb further argues that “we become human only in the company of other human beings” (563). Using personal voices to verbally share thoughts and convictions is a part of creating a community of empowered individuals devoted to promoting change. The power of society is understated in the world today; living in solitude is easier and more comfortable. The harsh reality is that man flourishes in gatherings of likeminded people but shrivels up in isolation. To make an impact on the world and take part in bettering the future for tomorrow’s children, a brotherhood of individuals will have to band together to promote the needed reform. An association of people will have to break off the bonds of isolation and be willing to join a movement with the intention of promoting impactful revisions.

Loeb does a wonderful job articulating the personal effects isolation can have on oneself and the consequences seclusion has on active involvement. However, he only briefly describes the courage it takes to undergo personal reform, moving from the comfort of seclusion to becoming an active participant in the surrounding world. Isolation kills active involvement and diminishes the rewards of being a part of a community of people. As the inner spirit is crushed by solitude, self-deprecation prevails. The only way to break out of solitude is to embrace courage, using inner bravery to take the first step towards community. Once seclusion is broken the assumption that others will promote desired change disappears. The focus of a community gathering is to promote results that will create a better future. The question each citizen must ask themselves is who has the courage to stop living a life of isolation? Who is brave enough to start living a life of active involvement? If the known result is a better future for generations to come,

why wouldn't more people get actively involved? What is achieved today will benefit the quality of life tomorrow.

Works Cited

Loeb, Paul Rogat. "Making Our Lives Count." *From Inquiry to Academic Writing: A Text and Reader*. 5th ed., edited by Stuart Green and April Lidinsky. Bedford/St. Martin's, 2021, pp. 559-571.